

informed some of his best-known works, notably *Billy Budd* and *The Turn of the Screw*, which depict children and adolescents as symbols of purity and innocence menaced by evil and corrupt forces. Britten also enjoyed writing music for children, including the much-played *Young Person's Guide to the Orchestra* (1945) and the one-act opera *Noye's Fludde* (1958).

Cold War composition

In the context of the Cold War and the nuclear arms race of the 1950s and 1960s, Britten's pacifism took on a fresh urgency and relevance. Premiered in 1962, his emotional and dramatic *War Requiem* intermingled the Latin Mass with settings of anti-war poems by Wilfred Owen. It was commissioned for performance in Coventry Cathedral, rebuilt after its destruction by aerial bombing during World War II. Appearing at a time of international crisis, when nuclear war between the Western powers and the Soviet Union seemed possible or even imminent, the work had an astonishing public impact for a piece of classical music, the first recording selling more than 200,000 copies in six months.

It was partly in protest at the Cold War division of the world that Britten pursued publicized friendships with the Soviet composer Dmitri Shostakovich and Soviet cellist Mstislav Rostropovich, for whom he wrote his *Cello Symphony* in 1963.

In the 1960s, Britten was frequently denounced as a musical reactionary by avant-garde critics and composers committed to the idea that 12-tone serialism was the only valid form of contemporary music. But his work continued to be innovative in